
Nervous System Self-Assessment

Companion Workbook — build the literacy to read
your own nervous system over time

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Inner Circle Deep Cut — #4 Workbook

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Introduction

A YEAR-LONG COMPANION TO THE IC4 DEEP CUT.
Build the literacy to read your own nervous
system over time.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

THIS IS A LONG-HAUL WORKBOOK. USE THE DAILY check-ins to establish baseline (first 2 weeks). Use the weekly assessment for ongoing tracking. Use the seasonal check-ins quarterly.

Bring it to every session — and consider sharing relevant pages with your therapist if you have one.

CHAPTER 2

Establishing Your Baseline (First 2 Weeks)

FOR 14 DAYS, DO THE 5-QUESTION CHECK-IN three times a day. Just observe — don't try to change anything yet.

Five-Question Check-In Template

Use this format:

TIME: _____
1. Breathing: _____
2. Heart rate: _____
3. Hands (temperature/tension): _____
4. Mental state: _____
5. Facial expression: _____
MY GUESS AT STATE: [] Ventral / [] Sympathetic / [] Dorsal / [] Combination

Tracking Sheet — Day 1

TIME	STATE	NOTES
AM		
Midday		
Evening		

Tracking Sheet — Day 2

TIME	STATE	NOTES
AM		
Midday		
Evening		

Day 3-14

Continue the pattern. Use any notebook, app, or printed copy of this sheet.

CHAPTER 3

Baseline Summary (After Day 14)

MY MOST COMMON AM STATE: _____

My most common midday state: _____

My most common evening state: _____

My typical pattern combination (e.g., “wired but tired”, “mostly ventral with situational sympathetic”):

Three triggers I noticed reliably activate me:

1.

2.

3.

Three triggers I noticed reliably shut me down:

1.

2.

3.

CHAPTER 4

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: BEFORE READING THIS DOCUMENT, how would you have described your “energy” or “stress level”? After two weeks of check-ins, what do you actually see?

Prompt 2: What’s the longest you can recall being in genuine ventral vagal state — that “I feel like myself, present and at ease” feeling? When was it? What was different?

Prompt 3: If your nervous system could send you one message right now about what it needs most, what would it say? (No filtering — just write what comes.)

CHAPTER 5

Weekly Self-Assessment Protocol

DO THIS ONCE A WEEK, ONGOING. SUNDAY evening works well.

Week of: ____

State right now: _____

Predominant pattern this week:

- ☐ Mostly regulated (ventral majority)
- ☐ Sympathetic-dominant (activated most of week)
- ☐ Dorsal-dominant (shut down most of week)
- ☐ Volatile (swinging)
- ☐ Wired-and-tired (sympathetic + dorsal stacked)

Triggers I noticed this week:

What worked to shift my state:

What didn't work that I want to try differently:

Week of: ____

State right now: _____

Predominant pattern: _____

Triggers: _____

What worked: _____

What to try next week: _____

Week of: ____

State right now: _____

Predominant pattern: _____

Triggers: _____

What worked: _____

What to try next week: _____

Week of: ____

State right now: _____

Predominant pattern: _____

Triggers: _____

What worked: _____

What to try next week: _____

CHAPTER 6

Personal Intervention Library

BUILD YOUR OWN LIST OF WHAT RELIABLY HELPS each state shift.

To shift OUT of sympathetic (overactivation) into ventral:

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

To shift OUT of dorsal (shutdown) into ventral:

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

To maintain ventral when it's there:

1.

2.

3.

CHAPTER 7

Seasonal Check-Ins

Spring (March-May)

DATE: ____

**Activation level coming out of winter
(1=dorsal, 10=highly sympathetic): [__]**

Strategy for this season:

Summer (June-August)

Date: __

**This summer's activation pattern (energizing
or overwhelming):**

Rest commitment for the season:

Fall (September-November)

Date: __

Dorsal-tendency starting? (Y/N): __ / **Light exposure plan:**

Maintaining movement through fall plan:

Winter (December-February)

Date: __

Dorsal patterns showing up? (Y/N): __

Wired-and-tired stacked? (Y/N): __

Year-end reset commitment (per Module 12):

Daylight strategy (light box, morning sun, etc.):

CHAPTER 8

When to Seek Professional Mental Health Support

CHECK ANY THAT APPLY OVER THE PAST MONTH:

- ☐ Persistent depression or hopelessness lasting more than 2-3 weeks
- ☐ Anxiety significantly impairing daily function
- ☐ Trauma symptoms (intrusive memories, hypervigilance, flashbacks, avoidance) interfering with life
- ☐ Suicidal thoughts — **contact 988 (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline) immediately**
- ☐ Dorsal shutdown not responding to self-help, impacting work or relationships
- ☐ History of trauma surfacing
- ☐ Substance use increasing in response to stress

If you checked any of these — please make a plan to access professional support. This is outside the scope of self-help.

Resources:

- 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (call or text 988)

- Your primary care physician (can refer or assess for medication)
- Psychology Today therapist directory (psychologytoday.com/us/therapists)
- BetterHelp / Talkspace for telehealth therapy

Therapist name (when you find one): _____

First appointment date: ____

CHAPTER 9

Year-End Nervous System Inventory

COMPARED TO 12 MONTHS AGO, MY NERVOUS-system patterns are:

- ☐ Significantly more regulated
- ☐ Somewhat more regulated
- ☐ About the same
- ☐ Somewhat less regulated
- ☐ Significantly less regulated

Biggest shift this year:

What worked most consistently:

What I want to commit to for next year:

CHAPTER 10

Try this for 14 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Three 5-question check-ins per day for two weeks. AM, midday, evening. Just observe — don't try to change anything.

That's the baseline-establishment exercise. Most people are surprised by what they find.

After 14 days you'll have data on your actual nervous-system patterns. That data is the foundation for everything else.

Bring this workbook to your next session.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
LMT and published by Healing Hands By
Nate.